

Moonsea Rising - 20230730

Helpmoot

As Beatrice gives Baron Steele her message, he seems taken off guard. His skin darkens slightly, and he tells her, "I shall... use the same passphrase." Taevyn asks his lord, "and, will you be telling us the passphrase my lord?" The Baron sputters momentarily. "Boy, how would that be wise? We are trying to ensure that a shape-changing hag is not able to deceive one or the other. Exposing such a secret risks that endeavor."

As Taevyn sulks at the rebuke, a servant enters and announces the return of Lord Harken Betany, who follows him into the room, walking normally. He greets the nobles he knows, Voight, Steele, and Marsk, as well as noting their retinue. The Baron has brought Taevyn and Lennox with him, and Lirael is seated by the Baroness. He asks Beatrice how much of Agatha's doing has been discussed. She has discussed the majority of their interactions in detail, while staying away from the details of their compatriot's passing.

Lord Betany speaks more about what they found in Jambis, and that they had to make several deals, including a vase to given to Baron Steele. Beatrice's counsel is that he smash it, having received it from them. Lirael inspects the magic, and suggests that perhaps that isn't the wisest action. It seems to be soulbonded to someone, and she surmises from Beatrice's aside that it is likely Baron Steele. She advises that the Baron guard it well, but prevent it from coming to harm if he is able; neither to further interact with it if he is able.

Baron Steele designates Taevyn and Lennox to act as his proxy in the handling of Agatha; Lirael asks to come along as well. She offers that the hags might be a symptom, rather than a cause of the ills befalling the county. Something is moving in the natural world. Beatrice mentions the vampire in Mooten, the ghast in Stavys, and that Agatha mentioned Goldpebble. Lirael recalls a fable of a gold dragon by that name, who cut off and cursed a noble's lands for stealing his hoard. She notes that this is just a story, but perhaps Agatha's foe feels this fable represents them in some way, and has taken the name as a symbol. Harken recalls that Goldpebble was the reason the bridge over the Gold Canyon will never be repaired.

Baron Steele seems deeply interested in the possibility of a dargon to slay, though Lirael cautions him that not all dragons are evil despoilers of the countryside, and that he might not wish to hunt a good dragon to make his name.

Return to Jambis

Lady Marsk is still quite upset about the spiders in the Webwood, though she wants to see what kind of humanitarian aid is needed in Jambis. Lirael tells her the spiders of the woods were little enough trouble before they were cursed, and that the silk harvest was a major export for the region. As they approach Jambis, Harken and Beatrice both begin to look grim and shaky, as though they'd rather not return to the town. Taevyn and Lennox offer to go into town, and Lirael offers to accompany them, offering sympathies to Harken and Beatrice for what they've gone through. As

they ride in, a barrel chested man with a white beard leaps down from one of the buildings being cleansed of webs and greets them. Taevyn asks if he's Clarence, which he is, and asks if they remember anything, including offending a cleric of Lathander. He is confused and tries to accommodate Taevyn's questions, but is having difficulty following along. He seems to believe it is still two years ago.

Lirael tells them that the spiders were ensorcelled, and that if they are unable to remember, then it is probably for the best. The crowd starts to panic, but she calms them down, and tells them that they are safe now, and should count the forgetting a good thing. That they are there to help assess the damage, and see what aid the county can provide them. They tell them they plan to ride on to the Baron's estate and see what in what state he finds himself.

Back on the road, Beatrice apologizes to Harken for her refusal to enter Jambis, and asks if he himself is alright. Harken reassures her, unconvincingly, and they sit in awkward silence with their memories. When the three return to them, Beatrice asks about the villagers, and Taevyn says they're seriously messed up, and remember nothing. He asks if the big one is the one who, "ate her friend?" Beatrice stiffens at this, but agrees that he is. Taevyn tells her he doesn't think he remembers, and Lirael adds that she is sure he does not.

Moving onto the estate, Frater Mosley meets them, effusive in his gratitude for lifting the curse. Beatrice rather sharply reminds him that the curse is not lifted, only in abeyance pending the completion of their agreements with Agatha. Taevyn remarks that he, "must be as stupid as Clarence," which takes the Frater aback. Noting Taevyn's livery and bearing, he treats him with the respect due his position as Steele's ward.

Beatrice asks him about clearing out the stinging vermin in the manor, and he assures her they have been dealt with. Glancing towards the greenhouse, it appears that they have just boarded everything up, which she notices with distaste. There are also boards laid across the pit trap, which the Frater quickly crosses to announce their arrival to the Baron. She attempts to get the guards to tell her if the creatures have been dealt with, and they are reluctant to do so, or to contravene what Frater Mosley has said. Mosley returns, and tells them the Baron will meet with them in his chambers. They follow the Frater into the main hall of the manor.

Baron Telus is an older, but not an old man. He is grossly obese, but seems to be sane and vaguely believes that he knows some party. He identifies himself as Aaroach Telus. The Frater identifies Harken and Beatrice, but he only identifies Taevyn, Lennox, and Lirael by their trappings. Lirael tells him the Silverweave's speak well of his Barony's silks. The man is oleaginous, explicitly ensuring they feel welcomed by his hospitality. He is deeply concerned with getting the manpower to restore his Barony's industry; woodworkers, farmers, silkwrights. It is clear acting hospitable is difficult for him, and he would very much like to hit Taevyn for his manner. Lirael reminds him to have the silks from the cleanup boiled as they go, as the bounty is likely to be able to fund much of the restoration. He sees the wisdom of this immediately, and agrees to look into it.

Back outside, Beatrice asks after Jim Smythe, the brother of someone who had asked after their kin in Jambis. He tells her he was their escort out of the Barony. She growls that he was the one who had betrayed them to the hags. She passes on his sister's message, in case he returns, but warns that he should avoid Beatrice at all costs.

On to New Towne

New Towne seems not to have been caught up in the Webwood's curse. Beatrice tells her New Towne was the desmesne of Agatha's sister, and she doesn't know what she was doing, but her touch seems to have been lighter. Lirael casts detect magic and, while there is no enchantment on New Towne now, there are echoes of powerful fey magic. Beatrice hails a shepherd driving his sheep across the bridge, and he tells her Mayor Vort can be found in the tavern, where she resolves to go to see what the state of the town is. Harken asks Lirael about the fey fleeing the region, and what might be causing it. She tells him that the fey are tied to their domains, and a threat so great to the wyld magic deeply troubling.

As they enter the tavern, they find only two people at a table: Cavidius Vort and Cadmus Callahan. Lirael stiffens on seeing Cadmus, as Vort invites them to sit, and tells them they have much to discuss. Cadmus accuses them directly of treason, and suggest they surrender, rather than be killed. As several men rise from behind the bar, and the door bars behind them, Taevyn draws his rapier.